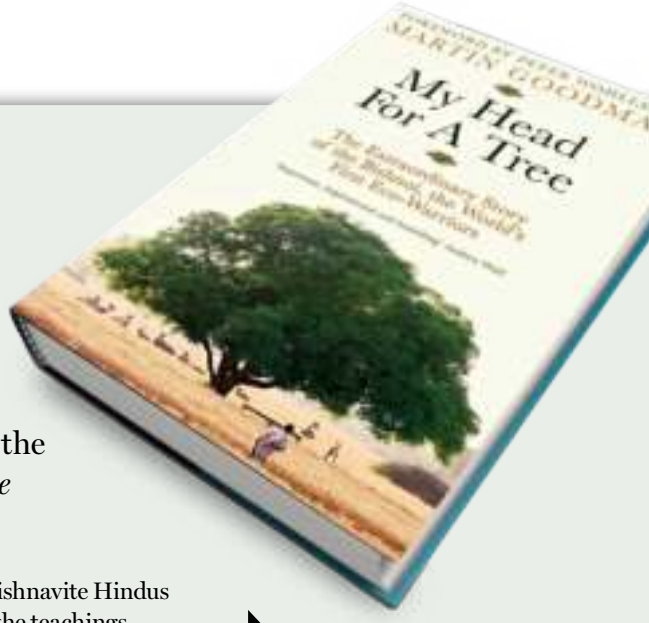
BOOKS ▼

Fighting the **Good Fight**

The environmentalism of Rajasthan's Bishnoi is the subject of **Martin Goodman's** *My Head for a Tree*



In May, Radheshyam Bishnoi died in a road accident near Jaisalmer while trying to intercept poachers. Devoted to protecting the critically endangered Great Indian Bustard, the 28-year-old conservationist did not merely profess environmentalism; he lived it. Like many others of his ilk, he paid with his life.

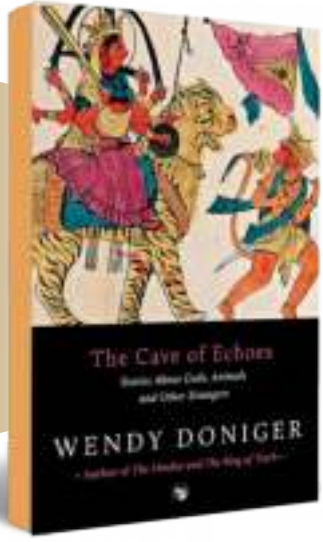
In the 1990s, the Bishnoi made news for bringing actor Salman Khan to justice for hunting blackbuck on their lands. Martin Goodman's *My Head for a Tree* attempts to clarify the context of their fierce activism.

The Bishnoi are Vaishnavite Hindus who owe allegiance to the teachings of Guru Jambheshwar, a 15th-century mystic. "A tree covered in greenery is my temple and my home," Jambhoji declared, advocating compassion to living things. Indeed, an oft-circulated and endearing cliché is an image of a Bishnoi mother suckling, on each breast, her own infant and a chinkara fawn.

Jambhoji's teachings extend the Bishnoi's nurturing love to the stewardship of everything from bustards,

MY HEAD FOR A TREE: The Extraordinary Story of the Bishnoi, the World's First Eco-Warriors
By Martin Goodman
PROFILE BOOKS/ HACHETTE INDIA
₹699; 272 pages

THE LISTICLE — RECENT BOOK RELEASES THAT SHOULD BE ON YOUR READING LIST



THE CAVE OF ECHOES
By Wendy Doniger
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 240 pages

Telling Tales

This is the reissue of a seminal text by the Indologist Wendy Doniger which was first published in 1988 by the University of Chicago Press. Rather than dwelling on specific myths and tales, for which she is of course much admired and loved, in *The Cave of Echoes,* Doniger puts the very act of storytelling front and centre. This is a book that deals "with stories about stories—metastories, or, more specifically, metamyths". It draws on storytelling traditions from around the world, including Hindu and Greek mythology, Biblical parables, and even modern acts of mythmaking a la Woody Allen and soap operas to illustrate how myths help cultures define themselves. Doniger considers it less a collection of essays and more a "tapestry of threads" or "sutras". Drawing connections across cultures and timespans, she gives us much to ponder about.